

Editorial

In this final editorial for Volume 22 of the ISJ, we introduce a new style of editorial writing. In the past, each editorial was co-authored by all the Editors-in-Chief. However, we will now change this arrangement, with each Editor-in-Chief authoring editorials in sequence. Thus, Robert Davison is the author of this editorial, Eileen Trauth will author the first issue of 2013 and Philip Powell will author the editorial after that. We will rotate the editorial authorship in this fashion in the future.

In this issue of the ISJ, we present four papers covering the following topics: 'agile distributed software development'; 'agile methods in IS development'; 'the (dis)placement of women in the IT workforce' and 'competency models for requirements analysts'.

Before I get to the papers, I'd like to share some thoughts in what will be the first of several occasional commentaries where I reflect on IS research and the role that I see the ISJ playing in the discipline. In this editorial, my focus is on novelty – in IS research. I selected this topic because, as an incoming co-Editor-in-Chief, I am interested in encouraging more novel research to be conducted and submitted to our top journals. Indeed, in our opening editorial (22-4), we (the new co-Editors-in-Chief) wrote: '... we will continue the *ISJ* tradition of publishing high quality, yet "risky", papers that help to move the IS field forward' (Davison, Powell & Trauth, 2012). I see novelty in IS research as an example of that kind of riskiness. Clearly, novelty can be a fad, and I am not encouraging faddishness! Submissions to the ISJ that deal with novel or risky topics will be subject to the same high standards of reviewing as any other. But novelty is nonetheless important for a number of reasons.

Novelty in research is important if for no other reason than the distaste of most journals and readers, notably those in practice, for old material. The dichotomy here is deliberate, and certainly there are many shades of grey in between. However, I feel that we are currently embedded in an era (even a paradigm) of nano-incrementalism, where the slightest minor addition to a research model or theory appears to be sufficient to warrant publication. I suspect that this situation has arisen from a combination of factors, among them: the mentoring and advising styles of PhD supervisors, who prefer well-done simplicity; the conforming nature of the review process where it is easy for novel and radical ideas to be struck down; and the entropic effects of tenure clocks where the 'publish or perish' maxim is constantly present (i.e. don't risk your tenure by embarking on a major project that will not be published in time).

This does not mean that all research should be radically novel, but I do believe that authors could and should be more adventurous in their research designs and intents. See, for instance,

Martinsons' (2008) development of a context-specific theory of relationship-based e-commerce and Lee & Dennis' (2012) hermeneutic (re)interpretation of a GSS laboratory experiment. A typical example of inadequate novelty I come across often relates to research replication. A well-established research model, framework or theory is retested in a new context (country or culture). However, no attempt is made to describe the salient, local features of that context, or even to determine if the model, framework or theory is actually valid in that context. Perhaps some authors and readers are uninterested in this, believing that IS research is the same everywhere, regardless of social reality or context? Regardless, the only new thing is the data. If nothing else, this is a missed opportunity. If you are going to go to the trouble of collecting local data, then why not also identify local variables that are culturally salient and that may affect your outcomes? You might in this way identify a new construct or variable that potentially has relevance for other contexts – and so make a rather more substantial contribution to knowledge.

In the first paper, John Stouby Persson, Lars Mathiassen & Ivan Aaen (2011) investigate the challenges associated with the need for face-to-face interaction in agile software development that are also characterised by distributed environmental contexts, where mediated communications are more usual. The context of this paper is a successful Russian–Danish agile software development project, which they analyse through an in-depth case study. They demonstrate how control in the project was enacted through a mix of formal and informal means, even though most communication was mediated not direct.

In the second paper, Xiaofeng Wang, Kieran Conboy & Minna Pikkarainen (2012) blend agile methods with innovation assimilation, overcoming the tendency of prior agile methods research to be descriptive and atheoretical. Drawing on evidence from four case studies, and focusing in particular on the later stages of assimilation, viz.: acceptance, routinisation and infusion, they glean interesting insights into the XP and Scrum agile methods practices. As the authors note, their 'adapted concepts of agile practice assimilation stages can be applied as a theoretical lens for other empirical studies on agile methods in use to explore the factors behind different assimilation stages of agile practices'.

In the third paper, Jeria Quesenberry and Eileen Trauth (2012) draw on the individual differences theory of gender and IT to critically examine the career anchors of women IT professionals. The results of the analysis indicate that organisations need to be aware of the diversity and natural variation among women in the IT workforce as they plan workforce changes. The direct implication of this diversity is that a stereotypical 'one size fits all' approach to women will be singularly inappropriate in organisational contexts. Furthermore, in planning for future generations of the IT workforce, current gender-related stereotypes in the public domain need to be modified. Girls currently at school may then be able to develop appropriate attitudes towards the IT workforce and recognise potential opportunities for their own employment.

In the final paper, Ruth Klendauer, Marina Berkovich, Richard Gelvin, Jan Marco Leimeister & Helmut Krcmar (2012) develop a competency model for requirements analysts. They undertook a qualitative investigation, using the critical incident technique, with 64 interviewees at 8 major North American and European financial services companies. The competency

model that they develop identifies 16 critical competencies, integrating both contextual and situational factors. They find that effective analysts must maintain close interaction and communication with customers, but also that the customers' expressed needs must be closely questioned.

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